

B General Building Contractor — Licensing Checklist

California Contractors State License Board (CSLB) · pathtotrades.com · Updated March 2026

Timeline	Total Cost	Bond Required	Workers' Comp
4–12 months	\$900–\$2,000+	\$25,000	Exemption available (until 2028)

Step 1: Verify 4 Years Multi-Trade Experience

Before applying · \$0

■ **Must show breadth across 2+ UNRELATED trades**

- Experience forms covering multiple trades
- W-2s, pay stubs, tax returns (4 years)
- Education transcripts (if substituting up to 3 years)

Tip: CSLB audits ~3% of claims. If audited, they want 4 years of documentation.

Step 2: Submit CSLB Application

1 day + 8–12 week wait · \$450

- Completed CSLB application for Class B General Building
- Experience forms attached
- \$450 fee — check or money order

Tip: Most versatile license — opens whole-building projects.

Step 3: Fingerprinting + Pass 2 Exams

1–3 months · \$200–\$580

■ **KEY STEP — B exam is broader than specialty exams**

- Live Scan (\$49–80)
- Law & Business: 115 Qs, 3.5 hrs, 72% to pass
- Class B Trade: 100 Qs, 3.5 hrs, 72% to pass — covers multiple trades + project mgmt

Tip: Law & Business: mechanics liens, payroll taxes. B trade exam is broad — allow extra study time.

Step 4: Complete Asbestos Open-Book Exam

1–2 hours · \$0

- Completed Asbestos Open-Book Exam & Verification Form

Tip: Quick and mandatory.

Step 5: File \$25,000 Bond + Insurance

1–3 days · \$250–\$600/yr + WC

■ **Most GC clients REQUIRE WC for bid qualification**

- \$25,000 surety bond certificate
- BQI bond if applicable

- Workers' comp certificate (or exemption until 2028)
- General liability insurance (recommended \$1M+)

Tip: GCs typically need higher liability than specialty contractors.

Step 6: Pay License Fee

1–2 weeks · \$200

- \$200 payment (\$350 non-sole owner)

Tip: 5 hrs CE required each 2-year renewal cycle.

Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost	When Due
CSLB application fee	\$450	With application
Live Scan fingerprinting	\$49–\$80	During processing
Exam prep course	\$150–\$500	Before exams
Contractor bond premium (annual)	\$250–\$600/yr	Before license issued
Workers' comp (strongly recommended)	\$800–\$2,000+/yr	Before license issued
General liability insurance	\$500–\$2,000+/yr	Before bidding
Initial license fee	\$200–\$350	After passing exams
TOTAL FIRST YEAR	\$900–\$2,000+	
Renewal (every 2 years)	\$450 + bond + WC + 5hrs CE	Before expiration

This checklist is for informational purposes only and is not legal advice. Verify all requirements at cslb.ca.gov before submitting your application. Bond amounts and fees are current as of March 2026.
pathtrades.com — Free step-by-step licensing roadmaps for California construction trades